KYOUNGMIN CHO

Department of Philosophy, Mount Holyoke College
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Academic Employment

Visiting Assistant Professor, Mount Holyoke College — 2024 – Present

Education

University of Illinois Chicago (UIC), Ph.D. in Philosophy — 2016 – 2024
Dissertation: *Ends in Activities*
Committee: Anthony Laden & Will Small (co-chairs), Marya Schechtman, Justin Vlasits, Anton Ford (UChicago)

University of Wisconsin–Milwaukee (UWM), M.A. in Philosophy — 2013 – 2015

Columbia University, Teachers College, Ph.D. Student in Education — 2012 – 2013

Korea University, M.A. in Education — 2009 – 2011

Korea University, B.A. in Education & Sociology — 2002 – 2009

Research & Teaching Areas

Areas of Specialization
Philosophy of Action, Ethics

Areas of Competence
Medical Ethics, Personal Identity, Metaphysics, Aristotle, Kant

Papers

"The Problem of the Infinite Regress of Ends" (forthcoming in *Ratio*)

"On Aristotle's Test for *Energeia*" (forthcoming in *The Review of Metaphysics*)

"On Actions as Ends in Themselves" (under review)

"Ends in Action: Production, Activity, and Actions as Final Ends" (under review)

"Actions, Processes, and Activities" (in progress)

"Against Mooreanism about Intrinsic Value" (in progress)

Talks

† Refereed

On Actions as Ends in Themselves
- Eastern APA Meeting Colloquium† — Jan 2026
- Neuchâtel Action Conference: Thin & Thick† — Dec 2023

Against Subjectivism about Ultimate Ends: The Argument from Fickleness
- Northwestern Society for the Theory of Ethics and Politics (NUSTEP)† — Jun 2023
- Texas Tech Graduate Philosophy Conference† — Apr 2023
- Central APA Annual Meeting Symposium† — Feb 2023

The Problem of the Infinite Regress of Ends
Eastern APA Meeting Colloquium† Jan 2023
St. Louis Annual Conference on Reason & Rationality (SLACRR)† May 2022

On Aristotle's Test for Energeia
26th Annual Oxford Graduate Philosophy Conference† Nov 2022
Eastern APA Annual Meeting Colloquium† Jan 2022
21st Annual Columbia-NYU Graduate Conference in Philosophy† Mar 2021
Central APA Annual Meeting Symposium† Feb 2020

Who is a Child?
American Educational Research Association (AERA) Annual Meeting† Apr 2019

Comments

"The Way Reasons Transmit to Necessary and Non-Necessary Means" by Seungcheul Yang Feb 2025
Central APA Meeting Submitted Colloquium

"The Order of Intentional Action" by Micha Glässer Mar 2023
Northwestern Practical Philosophy Workshop

"Between the Kingdom of Ends and the Doctrine of Right" by Khalilah Walters Feb 2022
Central APA Meeting Submitted Symposium

"Explaining What We Omit" by Grant Rozeboom Feb 2020
Central APA Meeting Submitted Symposium

Earlier Publications & Book Review (In Korean)

"교육철학자로서의 플라톤(Review of Eric A. Havelock, Preface to Plato)" 2012
in 시대와 철학(*Epoch and Philosophy*) 23(2), pp. 245–251

"로티의 듀이 해석의 정당성과 유용성(The Utility of Rorty's Interpretation of Dewey)" 2011
in 철학(*Philosophy*) 109, pp. 147–175

"듀이의 다윈주의 수용과 그 의의(Dewey's Acceptance of Darwinism and Its Significance)" 2011
in 사회와 철학(*Society and Philosophy*) 22, pp. 247–278

Selected Awards & Fellowships

UIC Dean's Scholar Fellowship ($30,000 plus tuition waiver) 2023 – 2024
Ruth Barcan Marcus Award (Outstanding Philosophy Graduate Student) 2023
UIC Award for Graduate Research ($1,998) 2022 – 2024
Korean American Scholarship Foundation Chair Scholarship ($2,000) 2022
McPherson Fellow at the Center for Ethics and Education ($10,000) 2018 – 2019
Fulbright Graduate Study Award ($70,000) 2012 – 2014

Courses Taught

At Mount Holyoke College

Self-Knowledge	Fall 2025
History of Modern Philosophy	Spring 2025, Fall 2025
Ethics	Spring 2025, Spring 2026
Action and Intention	Spring 2025, Fall 2026
Medical Ethics	Fall 2024, Fall 2025, Fall 2026
Personal Identity	Fall 2024, Spring 2026

Primary Instructor at UIC

What is a Person? Introduction to Philosophy	Spring 2019, Fall 2019
Introduction to Metaphysics	Spring 2021
Medical Ethics	Spring 2020
Introductory Logic	Summer 2019, Fall 2020, Summer 2021 Spring 2022, Summer 2022

Teaching Assistant at UIC

Introduction to Philosophy of Science	Spring 2021
Death	Spring 2020

Department Service

At UIC

Organizer, Work in Progress Series	2017 – 2019
Colloquium Committee Representative	2016 – 2017

Professional Service

Organizer, 2020 Chicagoland Graduate Philosophy Conference (canceled due to the pandemic)
Manuscript reviewer for *The Journal of Aesthetics and Art Criticism*, *Southwest Philosophy Review*

References

Research

Anthony Laden (laden@uic.edu)
Professor of Philosophy
University of Illinois Chicago

Will Small (wsmall@uic.edu)
Associate Professor of Philosophy
University of Illinois Chicago

Matthew Boyle (mbboyle@uchicago.edu)
Emerson and Grace Wineland Pugh
Professor of Humanities
The University of Chicago

Teaching

Nina Emery (emery@mtholyoke.edu)
Professor of Philosophy
Mount Holyoke College

Dissertation Abstract

Ends in Activities

My dissertation is about the ultimate source of justification for human action: it seeks to understand how the particular choices we make and the actions we thereby perform are ultimately justified. It addresses this issue by focusing on a venerable philosophical problem—the problem of the infinite regress of ends. I argue that this problem can be resolved by employing a neglected conception of action from Aristotle—namely, action as the activity (*energeia*) of a human agent. I maintain that activity in the Aristotelian sense is an end in itself and, as such, provides the ultimate source of justification for human action.

Why do we need an ultimate source of justification for our actions to begin with? Philosophers often answer that otherwise there would be an infinite regress of ends (e.g. Aristotle, Aquinas, Hume, Ross, and Korsgaard). But they seldom explain exactly how the regress arises or why it is problematic. In Chapter 1, I articulate the Problem of the Infinite Regress of Ends. I argue that, in paradigmatic cases, an intentional action is one that an agent performs for a reason, and that the action is rational in the minimal sense that the agent can explain and justify it by appealing to some end or good as her reason. Yet if the end appealed to is not to be arbitrary, and if its justification is not to be circular, the chain of action justification generates an infinite regress of ends. I argue that this regress is vicious because the order of action justification is an essential order whose justificatory force depends on an ultimate source. We therefore seem to face a trilemma: action justification must be arbitrary, circular, or infinitely regressive, and none of these alternatives seems acceptable.

A common way of solving the Problem of the Regress is to claim that there are *ultimate* ends that need no justification—ends that are simply given. In Chapter 2, I argue against a widespread version of this strategy, a view that I call *Subjectivism about Ultimate Ends*. According to Subjectivists (e.g. Hume, Williams, Smith, and Schroeder), ultimate ends are provided by unmotivated desires that are not based on reasons. I argue that this view fails because ultimate ends must be *sustainable* in the sense that there is a normative reason for an agent to retain her end while she is performing an action. Although unmotivated desires may in fact be *sustained* over time, an agent has no reason to retain them precisely because they are unmotivated. This mismatch between the temporal structure of ultimate ends and that of unmotivated desires poses a difficulty for Subjectivism.

In Chapter 3, I argue against another strategy for solving the Problem of the Regress, a view that I call *Objectivism about Ultimate Ends*. Some philosophers (e.g. Moore, Lemos, and Zimmerman) argue that the ultimate ends of human actions are to bring about states of affairs that are intrinsically good. According to this view, such states are intrinsically good in that they are good solely in virtue of their inherent properties and are good of necessity. But I argue that, once we consider the metaphysical status of states of affairs as bearers of intrinsic value, their goodness turns out to be defeasible—that is, they could turn out not to be good in light of what happens later. This shows that states of affairs cannot be necessarily good in the way that the Objectivist account of ultimate ends requires.

In Chapter 4, I present my own resolution to the Problem of the Regress. I argue that some actions are justified by themselves because they are ends for themselves, without thereby falling into circularity or arbitrariness. I call such actions *autotelic actions*. These actions are justified not because they are for the sake of some further end, but because in performing them an agent actualizes what she is. I argue that such self-actualization is a constitutive aim of action as such and is what makes an action an active manifestation of agency. Autotelic actions therefore derive their justification from what is constitutive of their being actions—the agent's active realization of herself as an agent. Because this activity provides an ultimate source of justification that does not itself derive its justification from a further end, the regress can terminate without arbitrariness or vicious circularity, while some of our actions remain rationally justified.